

Psalms 42

As the Hart Panteth

As the hart panteth after the water brooks
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *As the hart panteth after the water brooks, so panteth my soul after thee, O God.*
- 2 *My soul thirsteth for God, for the living God: when shall I come and appear before God?*
- 3 *My tears have been my meat day and night, while they continually say unto me, Where is thy God?*
- 4 *When I remember these things, I pour out my soul in me: for I had gone with the multitude, I went with them to the house of God, with the voice of joy and praise, with a multitude that kept holyday.*
- 5 *Why art thou cast down, O my soul? and why art thou disquieted in me? hope thou in God: for I shall yet praise him for the help of his countenance.*
- 6 *O my God, my soul is cast down within me: therefore will I remember thee from the land of Jordan, and of the Hermonites, from the hill Mizar.*
- 7 *Deep calleth unto deep at the noise of thy waterspouts: all thy waves and thy billows are gone over me.*
- 8 *Yet the LORD will command his lovingkindness in the daytime, and in the night his song shall be with me, and my prayer unto the God of my life.*
- 9 *I will say unto God my rock, Why hast thou forgotten me? why go I mourning because of the oppression of the enemy?*
- 10 *As with a sword in my bones, mine enemies reproach me; while they say daily unto me, Where is thy God?*
- 11 *Why art thou cast down, O my soul? and why art thou disquieted within me? hope thou in God: for I shall yet praise him, who is the health of my countenance, and my God.*

2 · CONTEXT

Opening Book II of the Psalter, Psalm 42 is the soul-thirsty lament of someone exiled from the sanctuary, remembering festive worship while surrounded by mockers taunting, “Where is thy God?” It alternates between honest despair and deliberate self-address—“Why art thou cast down, O my soul?”—a refrain repeated to steady faith rather than simply describe feeling. Paired with Psalm 43 as a single composition split for liturgical use, it models talking back to one’s own soul in faith instead of only listening to one’s emotions.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

As the hart pants after the water brooks, so the soul pants after God; it thirsts for the living God and longs to appear before Him.

Verse 3-5

Tears become his food day and night while enemies taunt, “Where is thy God?” He remembers leading the worshiping multitude to the house of God with joy and praise, then answers himself with the refrain: “Why art thou cast down, O my soul?... hope thou in God: for I shall yet praise him.”

Verse 6-8

His soul is cast down within him, yet he remembers God even from the land of Jordan and Hermon; deep calls unto deep at the noise of God’s waterspouts, and waves and billows have gone over him. Still, the Lord commands His lovingkindness in the daytime and gives a song in the night, a prayer to “the God of my life.”

Verse 9-11

He calls God “my rock” and asks why he has seemingly been forgotten, why he goes mourning under the enemy’s oppression—enemies who reproach him “as with a sword” by constantly asking, “Where is thy God?” The refrain returns once more: hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Spiritual thirst and felt distance from God are not the same as unbelief—they can coexist with real, if strained, faith. Deliberately preaching hope to one’s own soul, even mid-lament, is a legitimate and necessary act of faith, not a denial of genuine sorrow.

Application for life today.

When you feel “cast down,” practice the psalm’s pattern of speaking directly to your own soul rather than simply absorbing whatever it currently feels. Identify a past season of worship or closeness to God (like verse 4) to remember deliberately in a dry season now. Notice that even “deep calling to deep” affliction (v. 7) does not cancel God’s commanded lovingkindness—look for the “song in the night” He is giving even now.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What does spiritual “thirst” look like for you right now, and what practice might actually address it rather than distract from it?

2. Where do mocking voices—internal or external—ask you “Where is thy God?” and how might the psalm’s refrain answer them?

3. What is one specific memory of past worship (v. 4) you could deliberately recall to strengthen hope in a current dry season?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).